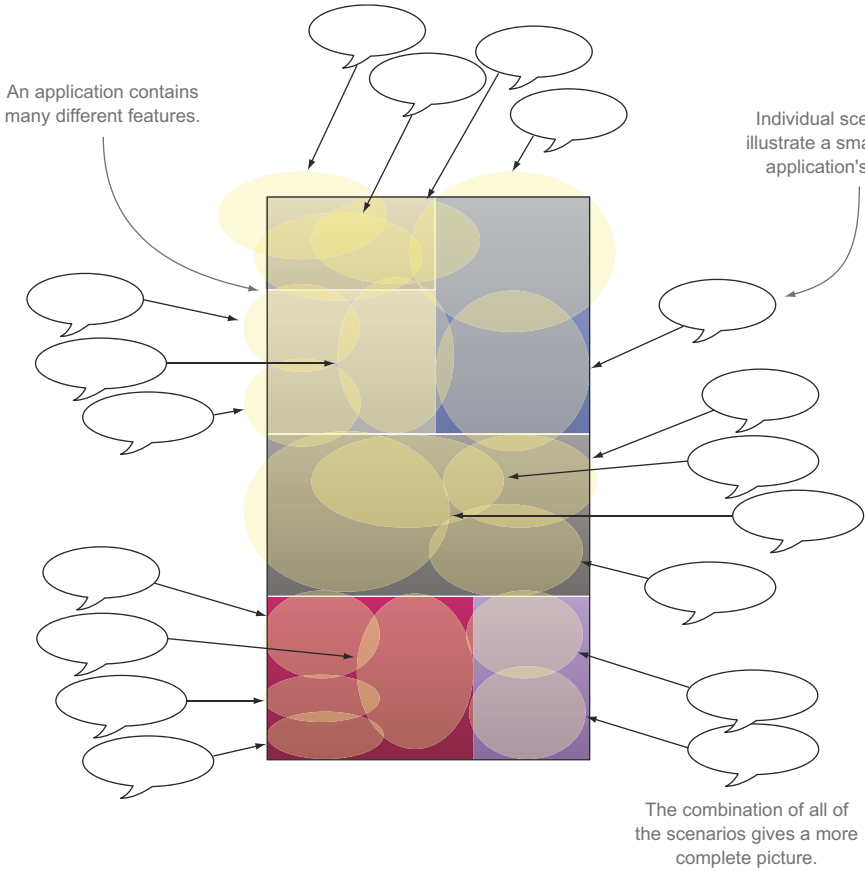


Figure 12.1 Only by considering all of the acceptance criteria together can you get a global picture of how the application is expected to behave.

Each specification should be able to run in isolation, and each specification should set up the test environment in the initial state it requires.

This is important for many reasons. If one of the acceptance criteria in a suite fails, the other acceptance criteria that depend on it will also fail, simply because the system isn't in the initial state they expect. This results in misleading reports that record working features as being broken and makes it harder to troubleshoot real issues.

In addition, when they're run as part of an automated build, executable specifications won't necessarily be run in a guaranteed order. Tests may be run in parallel batches, or simultaneously on different machines. Even on a single machine, many test libraries don't guarantee that tests will be executed in a predetermined order.

For these reasons, executable specifications shouldn't make any assumptions about which other specifications have (or haven't) been previously executed; if they need the system to be in a particular state, they should set it up themselves. Doing so results in more flexible and more robust test suites overall.